



KERALA/ VIZHINJAM PORT PROTESTS

ROUND 1 TO PINARAYI

By Jeemon Jacob

EYE OF THE STORM (Top) Police at the site of the Nov. 27 violence; right-wing outfit Hindu Aikya Vedi takes out a rally asking for the arrest of the rioters

In the end, it was Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan who came up trumps. The Latin Catholic church had led a 138-day protest by the fisherfolk against the Vizhinjam International Seaport Ltd, the Rs 7,525 crore deepwater container transhipment port project by the Adani Group, raising issues like sea erosion (through dredging for the port) affecting livelihoods and destroying homes of the fishing community, as well as compensation for those displaced. However, an orgy of violence on November 27 made their position untenable, and after meeting the CM on December 6, the Vizhinjam Protest Council (VPC) led by the clergy announced a provisional cessation of fire. Monsignor Eugine Pereira, general convenor of the VPC, later told reporters, "We are calling off the protests for now. The government has agreed to set up a monitoring committee to evaluate the impact of the shrinking coastal zone in the region."

For Pinarayi, the Latin church's retreat comes at an opportune moment, with his government already under attack on several fronts. The political victory boosts his strongman image and deflates the opposition charge that he was going soft on the rioters due to the "pressure politics of religious groups".

Not many would have bet on events unfolding in such a manner after the events of November 27. The fishing hamlet of Vizhinjam in Kerala's capital Thiruvananthapuram resembled a war zone with 64 policemen injured, and the FIR naming some 3,000 rioters, including Thiruvananthapuram Latin Catholic Archbishop Thomas J. Netto and nine other men of the frock. "The attack on the police station and the ensuing violence were pre-planned," says M.R. Ajithkumar, additional DGP, law and order. Before the attack, the crowd rang the church bells to mobilise people and removed all CCTV cameras in the area.

The ADGP says his force showed "extraordinary restraint" in the face of extreme pressure. "We had been monitoring the situation...the sole aim of the November 27 violence was to create a situation that would force deadly retaliatory action by the police," says Ajithkumar. This was despite the VPC's assurances to the high court that they would not stall the ongoing construction at the port site and that the protests would be peaceful.

The situation was a far cry from 2015 when then archbishop Soosa Pakkiam had welcomed the announcement of the Vizhinjam project. Conceived as competition to major international ports in the neighbourhood like Colombo and Singapore, it has seen multiple delays, local remonstrations being a key factor.

The church fanned the flames, but had to back off after the anti-port violence